Australia and the Vietnam War



AUSTRALIAN WAR MEMORIAL P01404.028

Year 10

Name:

History Set:

Class Teacher:

Approaching Sources:

There are four types of source question you should be prepared for on the Mid-Year Examination

- **Extract information from sources (According to Source A…)**
- **Using Source A and your own knowledge**
- **Identifying the perspective of a source**
- **Explaining the value of a source**

Each of these is asking for a slightly different thing and calls for different approaches

Extract information from sources (According to Source A…)

- Wants you to find the answer in the source
- Your knowledge will help you make sense of the source, but should not be included

Worked Example: According to Source A, what were two challenges Australian troops faced in Vietnam? (2 Marks)

Source A: Extract *from The 5th Battalion's Approach to Counter-Insurgency, 1966* by Dr Robert O'Neill

When we were out on operations, a normal carrying load was around 30 kilograms. This included a lightweight, foldable shelter, water, food for up to five days, a weapon, claymore mines for ambushing, grenades and, heaviest of all, ammunition both for one's own weapon and for the heavy consumers such as our general purpose machine guns. Often there were additional heavy items to be portered such as bombs for our mortars. Patrols and platoons had to carry radios (for tactical communications, not entertainment) and their heavy batteries to be shared around whatever group needed them. The prevailing heat and humidity caused copious sweating, and the pressure of pack straps gave us sore shoulders as a constant accompaniment to patrolling.

Solution: Australian troops had to carry 30kg of supplies when they were patrolling. The weather was also humid and hot.

Using Source A and your own knowledge

- This is a normal content question, but you have been given a source to help you
- Your own knowledge should form the basis of your answer
- Start by thinking about what your answer to the question would be if the source wasn't there, then work out how to make use of the source
- This will normally either be to provide an **argument** or **evidence for an argument**
- You **MUST** make explicit reference to the source in this kind of question
- A good way to test that you have done this is to ensure that your answer says **'Source A'** at some point

Worked Example: Using Source A and your own knowledge, outline how 1ATF patrolled in the Vietnam War. (4 Marks)

Source A: Photo of Australian troops patrolling in 1965



AUSTRALIAN WAR MEMORIAL DNE/65/0133/VN

Answer:

1ATF generally used patrolling in the countryside in Phuoc Tuy to look for signs of the enemy in order to set up ambushes. They generally moved in complete silence, using hand signals and maintaining at least five metres between each soldier, with stealth and concealment prioritised above all else. They often moved in single file, as can be seen in Source A, though they sometimes used diamond formation. Before nightfall, a patrol base would be established, with scrapes dug, Claymores set and sentries posted.

Identifying the perspective of a source

- This question is essentially asking 'What is the view of this source?'
- This means focusing on two main questions:
    - Who created the source?
        - Think about name (could be of a person or an organisation), position/role, date
        - Think also about what type of source it is and what that might tell us about its purpose
        - In cases where the question doesn't explicitly tell you who is responsible for the creation of a source, you may need to infer this
    - What is the view of the source?
        - What is the person / organisation saying?
        - Are they critical? Supportive? Outlining? Trying to persuade you of something?
- You will need to go beyond what is in the description of the source in order to get full marks
    - Read what's actually in the source and identify key argument(s)
    - You will need to link what you've been given to your own knowledge to draw a conclusion about what the source is trying to say / argue

Worked Example: Identify the perspective of Source A. (3 Marks)

Source A: An extract from a petition sent to the Australian magazine on 19 June 1965
The undersigned young Australian male citizens, being of an age making us liable for military service, declare that WE OPPOSE OVERSEAS CONSCRIPTION because—
We believe that we may be sent to fight in Vietnam …This would be a moral wrong and an unjust call upon our lives by the Government of our country. We share a fundamental belief that to safeguard the future of our nation, Australia's role in these perilous times is to seek an end to South East Asian disputes, through negotiations for peaceful settlements—not to pursue the murderous path to world conflict, through prolonging the slaughter in Vietnam.

Answer: Source A is an extract from a petition written by an unnamed group of young men and published on 19 June 1965, not long after Australia announced it was sending ground troops to Vietnam. The young men are critical of Australia sending conscripted troops to Vietnam. They argue that diplomacy would be a better solution. They are also concerned by the violence and believe that Australian involvement will prolong the civil war.

Explaining the value of a source

- Asks you to work out why someone might use this source when writing a book or studying the subject – what about the source is valuable?
    - Your own knowledge will help you make sense of why the source is useful
- Answer is likely to revolve around perspective and content, and possibly form
    - Perspective – Why is this person's view valuable? Why do we want something from this person?
        - Possible Value – Expertise/knowledge, unique/rare, official position
    - Form – Why is this type of source valuable?
        - Eg Why might a photo be useful for this topic? Why might a memoir be useful? Why might an overview of the battle be useful?
    - Content – What does the source say? What might that be valuable?
        - Possible Value – Does the source suggest an argument? Does the source provide evidence for an argument?
        - Is it valuable for a particular period? Eg experiences in the early years etc
        - Is it valuable for impacts on a group? Reasons for victory? Causes? etc
        - For a visual source, you're looking for what the source *shows*: try to be more specific than just what you can see in the source if you can

Worked Example: Explain the value of Source A for an Historian studying the reasons for Australian involvement in the Vietnam War (5 Marks)

Source A: Extract from a 2021 journal article written by Dr Tom Richardson, *Australia in Vietnam and Afghanistan.*

The world view of the Australian politicians who committed to Vietnam was underpinned by several fundamental beliefs. They were staunch anti-Communists who thought, unlike those on the Left, that the conflicts spreading across Asia in the 1950s and 1960s were not the fruits of decolonization but part of a broader global struggle between democracy and Communism. After touring South Vietnam in July 1962 Foreign Minister Garfield Barwick wrote to Defence Minister Townley: 'This place should be regarded as our present frontier. We should give the locals as much support as we can.' For these men, the domino theory was not just a political construct – although they certainly exploited it domestically – but a genuinely held belief.

Answer: Source A is an extract from a journal article written by a military historian Dr Tom Richardson which is valuable as it written by an expert who specialises in military history. He is likely to have a great deal of detailed knowledge on the subject and has written the article with the intention of educating the public. As a journal article, its claims would have been checked by the editor. As a recent article, the source reflects up-to-date scholarship.
The source's content is valuable because it provides an overview of the reasons for Australian involvement – anti-communism, regional concerns, and Australia being part of a broader, global community. He also provides evidence for his claims with a quote from the Foreign Minister which adds weight to his claims.

Do: Would You Go to War?

Imagine each of the following situations. For each, decide if you would support Australia going to war. Record your reason(s) in the appropriate column.

SITUATION	SHOULD AUSTRALIA GO TO WAR?	REASONS
Australia has been attacked by Country X		
Country X is threatening to attack Australia		
Country X is building up arms and might attack Australia later		
Country X is likely to be an enemy in the future		
An ally of Australia in the region has been attacked by Country X		
An ally of Australia in another part of the world has been attacked by Country X		
Country X has a brutal dictator who is oppressing its people		
There is a civil war in Country X and one side is more pro-Australia		
Australia's biggest ally has attacked Country X and asked for support		

Read & Research: Political Ideologies

Read the table below and highlight what you see as the three most important differences between Communism and Capitalism. Then answer the following questions – most of these are based on your opinion, but you may need to do some research for a few of them.

Communism: a theory or system of social organization in which property is owned by the community and each person contributes and receives according to their ability and needs.

Capitalism: an economic and political system in which a country's trade and industry are controlled by private owners for profit.

COMMUNISM	CAPITALISM
Economic and political ideology in which property is owned collectively by the community	Economic and political ideology in which a country's trade and industry are controlled by private owners for profit
Each person contributes according to their ability and receives according to their needs	Each person receives according to their contribution
Goods are state-owned and distributed evenly among the people	Goods are privately owned and not distributed evenly, creating class distinctions
Normally has an authoritarian form of government	Normally has a democratic form of government
Society is classless and equal	Society has social classes separated by lifestyle and wealth
Profit from trade and products are shared by the people or entire community	Profit from trade and products belong to specific private individuals or entities
Market is state-owned and state-controlled	Market is free and independent, controlled by market forces with only some government intervention

1. List 5 communist countries: _____

   _____

   _____

   _____

2. List 5 capitalist countries: _____

   _____

   _____

   _____

Read: Why were Australians afraid of Communism?

The below is edited extracts from a 2004 speech by Associate Professor ***David McKnight*** *about the Cold War. As you read each section, write a one sentence answer to the question in the subheading. Then, highlight any argument or evidence McKnight suggests about why Australian politicians and the public were afraid of Communism during the Cold War.*

<u>What was the Cold War?</u>



I want to begin by defining what we mean by the Cold War. Many people attribute the phrase to the British writer, George Orwell, whose used the term 'cold war' in 1945 to contrast that period to a period of hot war - that is a war involving guns and bombs. But this is a little misleading. During the Cold war, it is true, that there was no direct military conflict between the communist bloc and the capitalist West, though the Cuban Missile Crisis in the early 1960s nearly caused nuclear war.

But the Cold War did involve plenty of guns and bombs-type conflicts. There was, for example, the Korean war and later the Vietnam war, both costing millions of lives as well as a strong of smaller wars. Whatever their local and specific causes, these conflicts were fought as wars by proxy between the US and communist bloc.

The transition to what became known as the Cold War happened very rapidly - just in the space of a few years - because when World War Two ended, the US, Britain, Australia were in alliance with the Soviet Union. But, by 1948 it was clear that the victorious Soviet Union was determined to colonize eastern Europe -- which it did with some brutality.

How did early developments in the Cold War lead to Australian fears about Communism?

Early developments like the Berlin Airlift symbolized to many people in the West that communism simply denied civil freedoms which they took for granted. Propaganda images showing stern-faced Soviet troops marshalling breadlines painted a stark picture of what life under a Communist regime would look like. The popularity of the phrase 'the Iron Curtain' which appears so melodramatic today, had some popular currency at the time.

In the late 1940s Communism was on the move elsewhere. In former colonies of Europe strong independence movements emerged, often with communists playing key roles. In Malaya and Vietnam such struggles ensued against respectively the British and French colonial powers. Most significant of all, was the communist victory in China in 1949 which sent shock waves around the world and gave rise to a belief that even more countries would fall like a line of dominos. In Australia this victory later allowed the Right to speak of a double-barreled fear of a red (Communist) and yellow (Racial) peril. And all these fears were heightened when the Soviet Union detonated its own atomic bomb in 1949, breaking the US monopoly.



Why did Robert Menzies try to ban the Australian Communist Party?

At home in Australia, the communist party -- the CPA -- was on the move as well. It emerged confidently from the Second World War with a large membership and a powerful base in the

unions. It also had big plans. Initially, the challenge it made was within the labour movement. The bitter coal strike of 1949 was a first sign, but in many other industries, the CPA urged a strongly militant stance and strikes were widespread.

The 1949 election saw the Liberal and Country parties win a majority, with a promise of being tough on Communism an important part of Menzie's campaign. Once in office he lost no time in drawing up a law to ban the CPA. Menzies regarded the communists as a treasonable force. So shortly after the bill banning the Communist Party passed through parliament, a series of raids on communist offices and the homes of CPA officials took place around Australia.

The Communists responded by challenging the law in court, with the High Court striking it down in March 1951 for violating the constitution. Menzies responded with a referendum the following September to change the constitution which was defeated by the narrowest of margins, 50.56% to 49.44%.

Extract from the official YES case – 1951 Referendum Pamphlet

'Communist activity in Australia has become a grave menace to our industrial peace, to production, to national security and defence. It is the enemy of defence and progress; it is the friend of inflation and disorder.

Australian Communist leaders have worked their way into positions of leadership in key trades unions, such as those relating to Coal-mining [sic], Shipping, Waterside work, Iron-working [sic], and Transport.

Unless we can meet and defeat this conspiracy in the next year or two years, we may find ourselves driven into a defensive world war inadequately prepared, and with insufficient resources.

FOR THE SAKE OF OUR SECURITY, PEACE AND DECENT PROSPERITY OF OUR COUNTRY, WE ASK YOU TO VOTE YES.'

<u>Why were Australian people and politicians so afraid of Communism?</u>

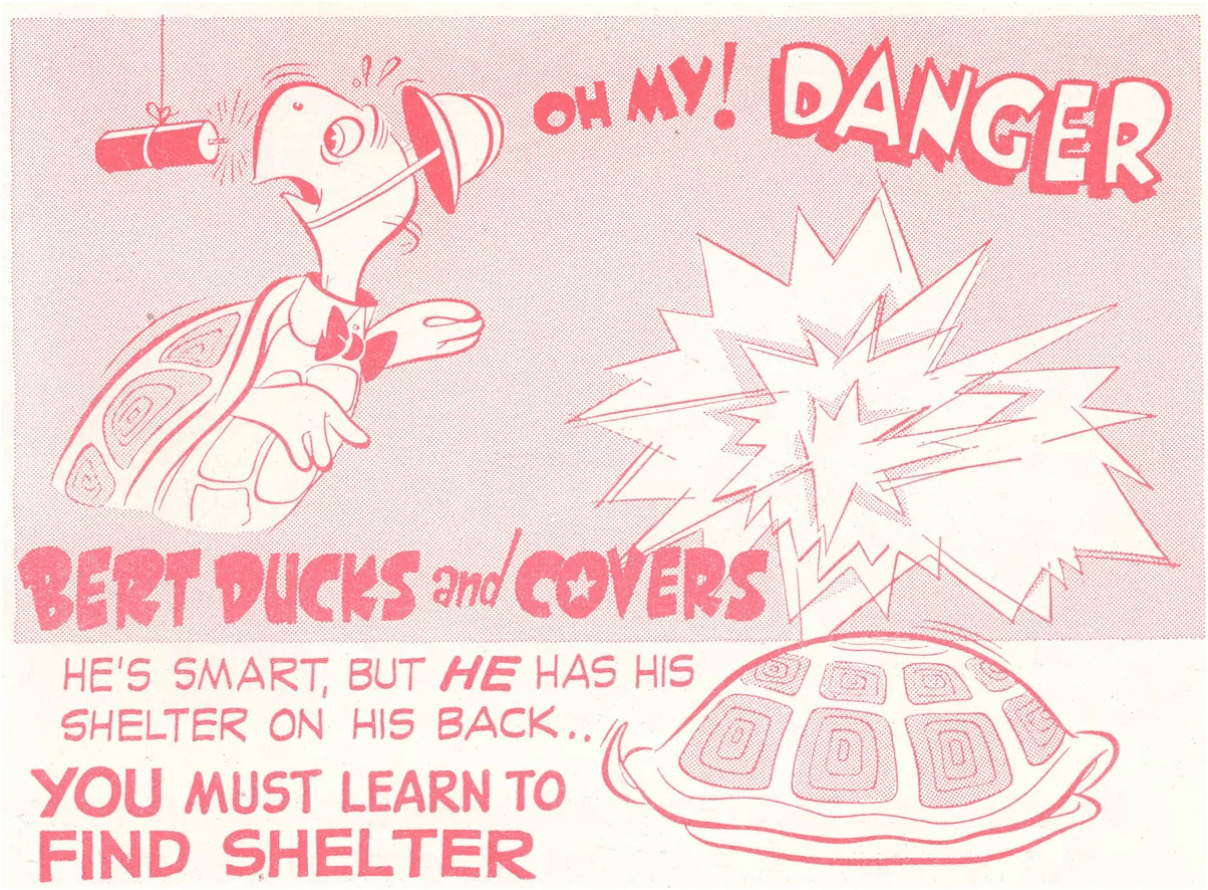
To many people this remains one of the puzzles of the early cold war. To us today the message about the fear of communism appears exaggerated, hyped, and hysterical. And it is certainly true that fear of communism was a very politically useful weapon which the conservative parties used to great effect at election after election. Beating the anti-Communist drum seemed

to drown out discussion on any other issues and to scare people into singing the one tune or staying silent. The accusation of communism was able to close off debate and shut people up.

But the puzzle remains: why were these fears accepted by a large number of people? Why was the accusation of communism so potent a weapon?

It is of course very easy to judge a previous historical period. The people are always more stupid than us - or more naïve - or more noble. Hindsight is a wonderful thing. But the people and the political players of the cold war were in fact very much like us - in the given circumstances of the time.

One of the challenges for people studying the Cold War is to try to think our way into the feeling of the times. For example, it gradually became obvious to me that my picture of the former ASIO officers and politicians some of whom I interviewed and about whose files I read were rather different from what I imagined. I had imagined that they were a rather grim, fanatical bunch who opposed the high minded and idealistic lefties who wanted to change Australia for the better. What I realised was that many of the ASIO officers and the anti-communists were of course, also idealists. And that in many ways the things which they did - and with which I disagreed - were the action of idealists - driven by ideals to sacrifice some freedoms in the passionate belief that that this was necessary to save even greater freedoms. Driven by ideals to label people who disagreed as soft on communism.



The other challenge to understand the cold war is one faced by anyone looking at history back over 60 years. And that is, that when we look backwards, we have to realise that what is now in the past was once in the future.

For example, we now know as a simple matter of fact that no direct conflict occurred between the Soviet Union and the West in the 1950s. But looking toward the future from a standpoint in 1950, this was by no means clear. A third world war was a possibility, it was genuinely believed. Western intelligence and defence officials sincerely believed that a Third World War with their erstwhile ally, the Soviet Union, could soon break out. Moreover, this view was shared by the intelligence and defence officials of the Soviet Union, which made various preparations, including alerting communist parties around the world to be ready.



In this climate, it makes sense that politicians on the right and intelligence officers, not to mention the Australian public, were afraid of Communism. They were concerned that Stalin -- whom they knew was responsible for mass murder of his own people -- was armed with the Atomic bomb. We now know that no Third World war ever took place. But this was not known in 1952 or 1953 or 54.

A final reason for Australian fears about Communism was the apparent progress it was making globally. As the debate around the Referendum swirled in Australia, North Korea had invaded South Korea and Australian troops and pilots were sent to fight there. But while a majority of Australians judged Menzies had gone too far with his ban on the CPA, for many people the fear of communism remained a legitimate concern because of the communism's victories overseas. These in turn created a climate in which many people began to believe that a new war would become possible. And for people who had just suffered a war this was a potent fear.

Word	Definition
	Australian Prime Minister who committed troops to Vietnam.
	Labor leader who opposed Australia's involvement in Vietnam.
	An agreement between countries to support each other.
	A formal agreement between nations.
	Compulsory military service
Guerrilla	
	Organisation formed to prevent communism spreading.
	Security alliance between Australia, New Zealand, and the United States.
	A rebellion against a government
	The continent where Vietnam is located
	Freedom from control by another country
	A system of ideas or beliefs, such as democracy or communism
Threat	
Security	
Conflict	

Dau Tranh

Communist Strategies in Vietnam

1

Dau Tranh (1)

- Literal Translation is 'One Struggle', but usually translated as Protracted War or People's Protracted War
- Involves dragging out the war for as long as possible while trying to influence enemy morale to get them to give up and go home
- Encompasses both a political and military struggle and integrates these together
- Philip Davidson (American General in Vietnam and later Historian): "a coherent, long-term, and brilliant grand strategy"

2

Why would protacted war / attrition be a "brilliant" strategy for the communists to use?

What will be necessary for the strategy to work?

Dau Tranh (2)

Political Struggle

- Action among your people
  - Total mobilization of propaganda, motivational and organizational measures towards the war effort
  - Done during all 3 Phases
- Action among enemy military
  - Subversion and propaganda to encourage desertion, defection and lowered morale among enemy troops
  - Mostly done during Phase 2
- Action among enemy's people
  - Total propaganda effort to sow discontent, defeatism and disloyalty among enemy's population
  - Mostly done during Phase 2

Military Struggle

- Phase 1: ORGANISATION AND PREPARATION
  - Building cells, recruiting members, infiltrating organisations, creating groups, spreading propaganda, stockpiling weapons
- Phase 2: TERRORISM & GUERRILLA WARFARE
  - Kidnappings, terrorist attacks, sabotage, guerrilla raids, ambushes, booby traps, setting up parallel governments in insurgent areas
- Phase 3: CONVENTIONAL WARFARE
  - Regular formations maneuver to capture key geographical and political objectives

3

Why was the HCM Trail so effective?

Organisation and Preparation



- The key factor here is the creation of the Ho Chi Minh Trail from 1959, which allows the Communists to transport supplies and weapons from the North to the South through neutral Cambodia and Laos
  - Varies from individuals walking down a narrow track to trucks on highways
  - Very dangerous – 25% died to Malaria ("Jungle Tax") and starvation (normal ration was 300g rice per day)
- Intensity of fighting was usually greater in provinces closer to the HCM Trail – Phuoc Tuy was about as far away as its possible to be
  - Worth noting, however, that the Phuoc Tuy's position near the Mekong Delta meant that there was still a high level of Communist activity, both because this was a haven for persecuted Communists before the war and because the Viet Cong were highly effective at using the many waterways for transport
- Also lots of organisation of Village cadres in the South starting with the creation of the NLF in 1960
  - The military wing of the NLF was formally called the PLAF, but mostly referred to as the Viet Cong

4

Why was the Mekong Delata more of an issue for the Australians?

Viet Cong

- Village guerrillas
  - Village, hamlet or local guerrillas were part-time fighters and helpers, carrying out minor harassment operations like sniping or mine/booby trap laying, building local fortifications or supply caches, and transporting supplies and equipment
  - Mostly peasant farmers
- The Regional Forces
  - Regional or territorial units were full-time soldiers but they generally served within or close to their home provinces
  - Not as well armed as the *chu luc* and usually operated in units that seldom exceeded company strength (<200 men)
- VC Main-Force Units (Chu Luc)
  - The elite of the VC, made up of full-time soldiers, many of whom were southern-born and had been trained in the north before re-infiltrating back to serve the Revolution
  - Majority were party members, wore the pith helmet common to the NVA and carried the same weapons
  - Typical battalion was similar to NVA: 400–600 men organized into 3 infantry companies backed by a fire support company
- Although manpower shortages sometimes intervened, a hierarchical promotion system was generally followed between the 3- levels: Promising guerrilla level operatives were moved up to the Regional Forces, and promising Regional Force fighters were promoted to the full-time Main Force units

5

Viet Cong Guerrillas





6

How might the content of these sources be valuable to an historian studying the VC?

Terrorism & Guerrilla Warfare (1)

- Controlling villages was a key part of Communist strategy and a major focus for them throughout the war
- This was done through a mixture of positive and negative action:
  - Sanders: "A judicious mixture of ruthlessness and frequent good behaviour gained the VC the sullen acquiescence or support of the peasants"
    - Provided land reform to distribute land among peasants, who had struggled for generations (going back to the French imperial period) against harsh taxes and unfair wealth distribution
    - Assassination of local government officials also helped with this process – approximately 37,000 kidnappings and 10,000 assassinations between 1958-1965 meant that South Vietnamese government officials in rural areas were mostly either incompetent, secretly communist or dead
  - Warner: "Their decentralized organization provided social services where the government could or would not, which increased their legitimacy with those they sought to convert to their cause."
- Largely successful in winning the villages' support, with around 80% of the countryside under Communist control by 1964

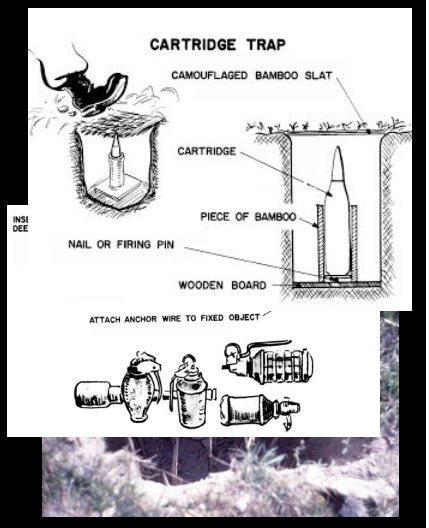
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What is grabbing the belt buckle?

Why would this have been effective?

Terrorism & Guerrilla Warfare (2)

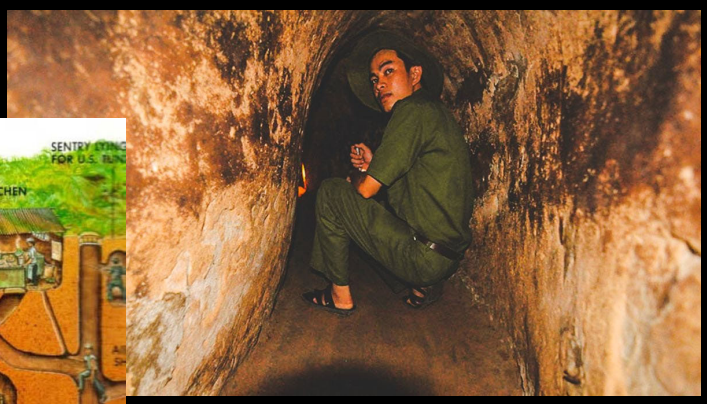
- Action normally revolves around hit and run ambushes in rural areas with small arms or mortars given the difficulty of directly confronting US and Australian soldiers
- Lots of Communist strategies were designed to mitigate the significant US/Australian firepower advantage
  - Grabbing the Belt Buckle
  - Tunnels
- Extensive use of booby traps designed to do psychological damage to American soldiers:
  - Punji Sticks and Cartridge Traps are good examples
  - These were often designed to injure rather than kill
  - Result: "It was hard to win the war when many of the grunts were terrified and demoralised" (Sanders)
- Minimal urban combat outside the mass uprising of the Tet Offensive in 1968
  - The most notable part of this in Phuoc Tuy was the Battle of Ba Ria, which was a decisive Australian victory

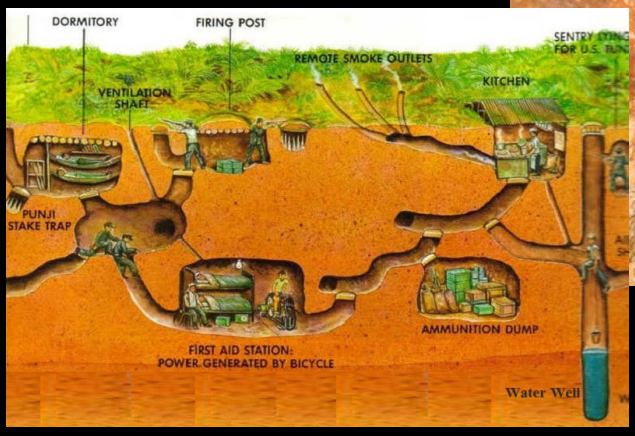


8

Why were mines and punji sticks so effective?

Cu Chi Tunnels





9 What the benefits of the tunnels for the VC?

Conventional Warfare





- Generally used sparingly as a diversion or psychological tactic given the significant US/AUS firepower advantage
  - Warner: "Knowing that the United States had an advantage in conventional warfare, [the Communists] lured the counterinsurgents away from population centres because they understood that the war was not over territory but over the loyalty and control of the population."
  - The Battle of Khe Sanh (pictured right) is a good example of this, although it only has minimal Australian involvement despite what Cold Chisel would tell you
  - The most notable example of this in Phyuoc Tuy was the Battle of Long Tan in 1966 (will be done in detail on its own)
- Would eventually be used as the strategy to win the war, but only after military and political dominance was achieved
  - There are a couple of false starts in this regard but only really happens after American & Australian withdrawal

10 Why didn't the communists engage in conventional warfare very often?

Guerrilla Warfare

Ho may have used the analogy of the 'elephant and the tiger', but in essence what he was describing was the fundamental tactic of guerrilla warfare. The Vietcong were not a homogenous group. Some of them were full time, highly trained fighters, often working in combination with northern regular troops; some were part of provincial forces who fought in specific areas. And then there were the part-time guerrillas who might farm by day and fight by night.

The tactics followed by the communist guerrillas owed much to the experience of the Chinese communists in their struggle for power. They included the following.

- They avoided major confrontations with American forces in which they would invariably be outgunned;
- They often attacked at night, operated in small groups, travelled light often carrying nothing more than a weapon, some ammunition and some rice.
- The VC used the tactic of ambush.
  - Booby traps could be anywhere – an American soldier might be walking along a track and then fall into a pit of sharpened bamboo **punji** sticks that had been hidden by a cover of grass.
  - Jungle tracks were often mined.
- The terrain of South Vietnam was well suited to guerrilla warfare.
  - Most of the country was jungle and mountainous. It is not easy for conventional forces like the American to move effectively through such terrain[1] but it is ideal for the lightly armed guerrilla.
  - The Vietcong also knew their locale intimately, another advantage for the guerrilla fighter.
- They wore no uniforms and so were able to blend in with the local population.
  - This made life very difficult for the American troops as they could never know who was a VC and who was an innocent villager. The people whom the Americans were fighting and the people whom they were defending dressed the same, looked the same and spoke the same language.
  - Out of frustration and fear, American soldiers often took no chances and played safe by assuming the locals they met were VC.
  - This caused hostility and in fact persuaded many South Vietnamese people to join the Vietcong.
- Anybody could be a VC. The old farmer working in his paddy field by day, the prostitute an American **GI** visited during **R and R**, or even the small boy to whom a GI gave chocolate and chewing gum.
- The Vietcong had a two-sided relationship with the local population.
  - Ho and Giap insisted on a high level of respect for villagers from their men. They were expected to assist them when they could, respect their women and deal with them honestly. Such behaviour earned the VC strong local support.

Mao Zedong had said: *"the army are the fish, the people are the sea."*

  - However, the VC could also be utterly ruthless to those who were suspected of working for the US or the South Vietnamese regime. Punishment for such people was always quick and merciless.
  - VC activity was thus marked by both idealism and brutality.

1 See Chapter 10

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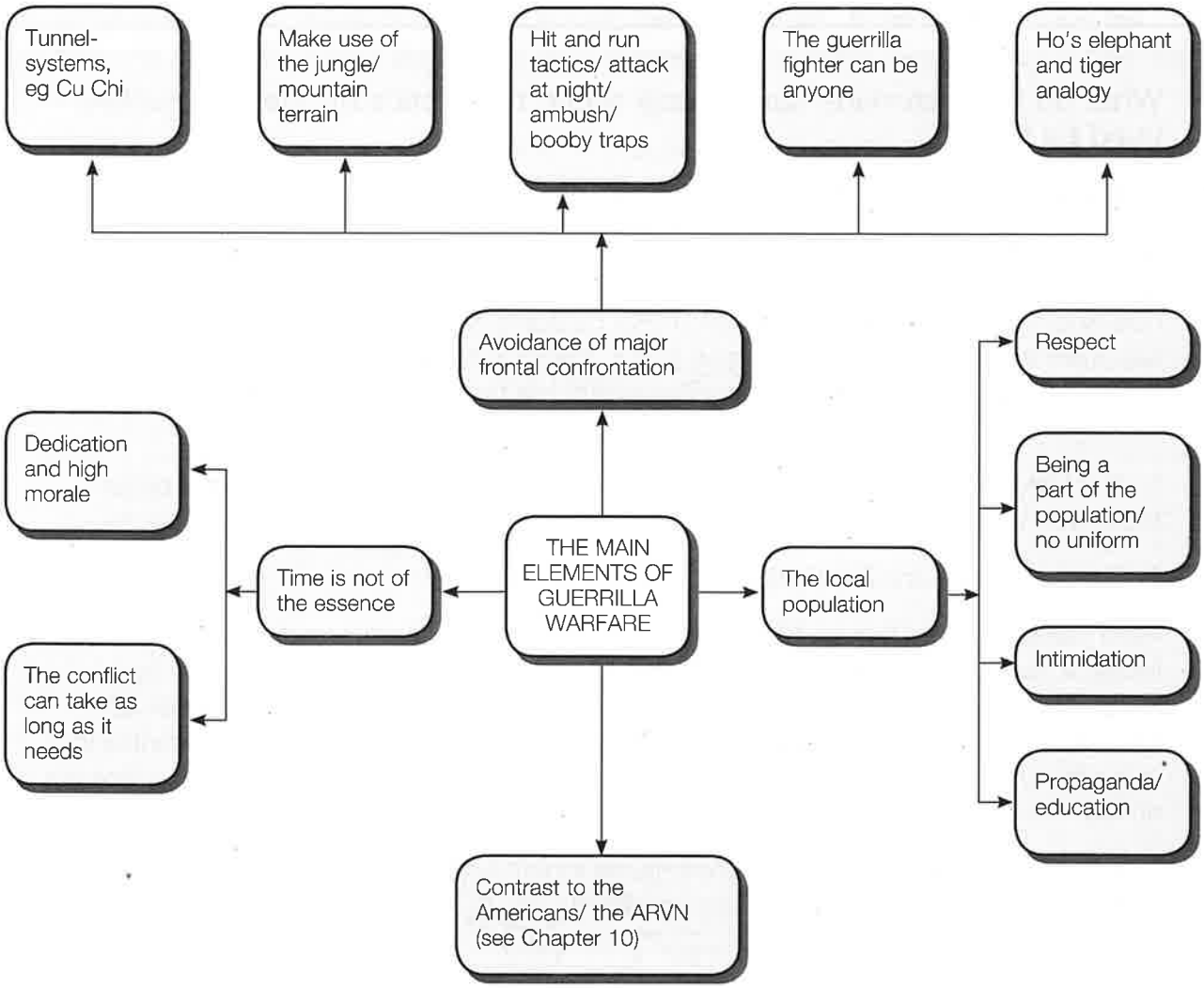
- Vietcong fighters also engaged in political propaganda. The South Vietnamese people were educated about the aims of the movement, about the aim of independence and freedom from colonial (US) control, and the prospect of greater equality after victory had been won.

Mao Zedong had said: *"the gun is useless if the trigger puller is not the missionary of an appealing cause."*

- Vietminh and later Vietcong fighters had developed kilometres of tunnels in South Vietnam which provided sanctuary for the guerrillas.
  - In places these tunnels were barely wide enough for a person to crawl through; in others places they broadened to areas large enough to accommodate sleeping quarters, supply depots and operating theatres.
  - They added further frustration to American soldiers when guerrillas seemed to vanish into thin air.[2]
- Most VC action occurred in rural areas. However, there were also urban cells; US soldiers always knew that the Saigon bar in which they were drinking could be blown up at any time.

Figure 9.1 summarises some of the main elements involved in guerrilla warfare.

Figure 9.1 Summary of the main elements involved in guerrilla warfare.



2 The Cu Chi network of tunnels north west of Ho Chi Minh City (Saigon) are now a major tourist highlight. Tourists can crawl through the tunnel networks for considerable distances.

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Exercise 9.1

Complete the following passage by using the terms from the box below.

Ho compared his nationalist fight to that between an elephant and a tiger; to Ho the _____ represented the elephant while the _____ represented the tiger. Ho believed that _____ was on his side, believing that the _____ of his troops would not falter, no matter how long the war went. VC guerrilla fighters usually fought at _____, in small _____, and engaged in hit and run _____ style attacks. With their superior knowledge of the _____, and the _____ topography and _____ vegetation, the guerrilla fighter had many advantages. The VC often had peasant _____ but they were also known for their _____ against their enemies. The VC were well supplied along the _____ trail and from 1964 were joined by _____ troops. They took over the brunt of the fighting following the VC losses in the _____ Offensive of _____.

terrain	morale	brutality	groups	Vietnamese	ambush
Americans	mountainous	time	support	night	Tet
1968	NVA	Ho Chi Minh	jungle		

What do the historians have to say about the tactics of guerrilla warfare used by the VC?

1. Stanley Karnow: Vietnam

Karnow relates stories of his visits to peasant communities in the Mekong Delta south of Saigon. Many peasants were indifferent to the fighting and merely favoured the side which harassed them less. However, he found many peasants who welcomed the Vietcong and saw them as liberators. Yet, as Karnow puts it, the VC's *"velvet touch often concealed talons of steel"*. However, VC brutality was not indiscriminate but aimed at those who betrayed the cause like government officials and informers.

"...The Vietcong benefited from the image of the Vietminh...and their promise of a better future was enticing...Yet for all their brutality, Vietcong terrorism was usually selective."[3]

2. Chester J Pach: (in) The Sixties: From Memory to History

Pach makes the point that by 1967, 96% of all American military engagements involved enemy forces no larger than a company, about 150 men. These were not the kind of battles that General Westmoreland wanted to fight.[4] Pach argues that these small scale battles usually occurred only when the VC wanted them to occur. As a result the VC were able to control their casualties and frustrate the Americans. In body count terms, the Americans invariably came out on top. However, Pach points out that despite the intensity of American bombing of the North:

"...Hanoi had increased the flow of reinforcements into South Vietnam and mobilised sufficient resources to carry on the war indefinitely..."[5]

3 Karnow, S, *Vietnam*, Century Hutchinson, London, 1983, p 232

4 America's commander in Vietnam, General William Westmoreland has been described as a logistics genius. He was the man to have on your side when involved in large scale, conventional conflicts. The guerrilla nature of Vietnam fighting did not suit him.

5 Pach, C J, *And that's the way it was : The Vietnam War on the network nightly news*, from Farber, D (ed) *The Sixties: From Memory to History*, University of North Carolina Press, Chapel Hill, 1994, p93

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3. Anthony Joes: The war for South Vietnam, 1954-75

Joes' disgust of Vietcong terror is such that he refuses to enumerate it and instead provides an alternative reference for readers seeking such information. He explains the significance of the campaign of terror carried out by the Vietcong. They targeted *'corrupt or oppressive officials to win popularity'* and *'hardworking, upright ones'* to intimidate the population and show that the Saigon regime could protect nobody. Teachers were particular targets as they could become opinion leaders in the villages. By 1965, over 25 000 civilians associated with the Saigon regime had been targeted and killed. Joes says that VC activity had a major negative effect on government activities but that more importantly:

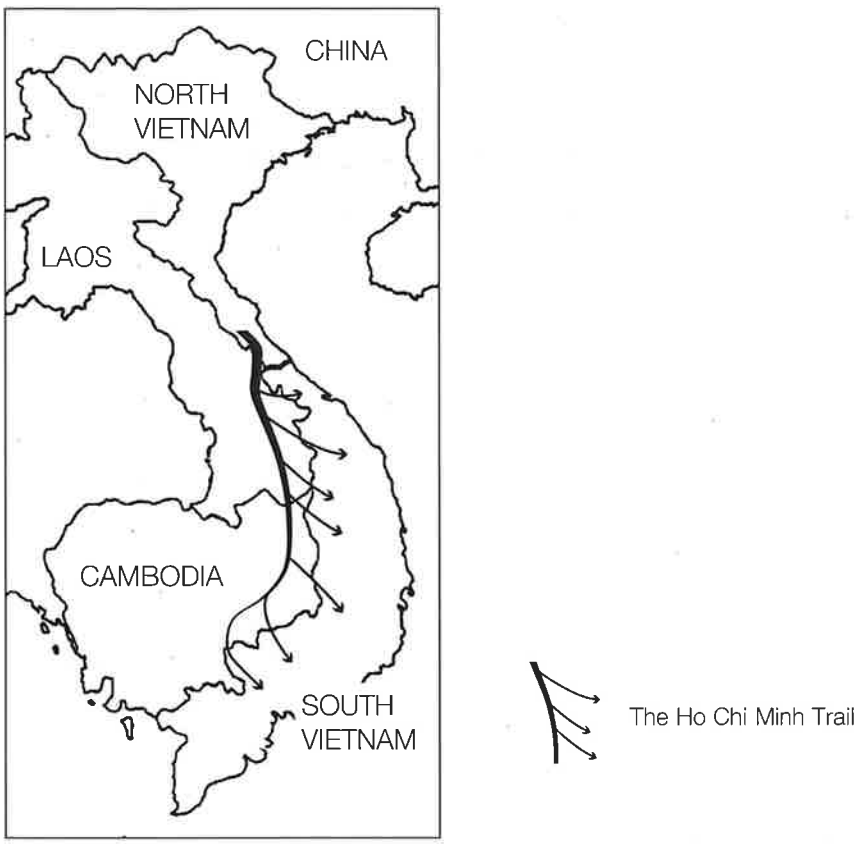
"...It would be difficult above all to overestimate the psychological impact of the constant terror. Through the most heinous attacks on innocent civilians, the Vietcong effectively taught the peasants the dangers of associating with the government..."[6]

The Ho Chi Minh Trail

Courageous and resilient and indeed brutal though the Vietcong might have been, they relied heavily on their Northern comrades for supplies, encouragement and reinforcements. With US air power so all pervasive, with half a million US troops on the ground by 1968, not to mention the forces of the ARVN, it was no easy task to keep the VC supplied. What made possible the movement of North Vietnamese (and Soviet and Chinese) supplies South, was the Ho Chi Minh trail or the Truong Son (high mountain) Trail.

As was mentioned in Chapter 4, the Ho Chi Minh Trail was not one simple track but a mass of criss-crossing routes, in places as many as twenty five, which varied enormously in size and quality. Some idea of the extent of the trail is shown in Figure 9.2.

Figure 9.2.
The Ho Chi Minh Trail



6 Joes, A J, *The War for South Vietnam*, 1954-75, Praeger, Westport CT, 2001, p 49

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ACTIVITY 2

What was the nature of the Australians' war in Phuoc Tuy Province?

In 1966 the Australians established themselves in Phuoc Tuy Province as their main area of operation. They set up a camp at **Nui Dat** as the base from which fighting forces would operate. Australian patrols set out from here, usually carried by trucks, armoured personnel carriers (APCs) or helicopters to a particular place, from where they started patrolling on foot. The soldiers were rarely sent beyond the reach of artillery support, so several artillery Fire Support Bases (defended outposts from where artillery could support the infantry) were set up to enable the patrolling troops' area of operations to be increased.

The Australians also created a supply base at the port of **Vung Tau**. Supplies and equipment would arrive here from Australia or from American supply bases in Vietnam (especially at Long Binh in Bien Hoa) and would be sent by road, inland water or air to Nui Dat.



John Rowe, *Vietnam. The Australian Experience*, Time-Life Books Australia in association with John Ferguson, Sydney, 1987, page 62

The enemy were of two main types — local guerrillas (**Viet Cong — VC**), who operated constantly in the area with the willing or forced support of the villagers; and **North Vietnamese Army (NVA)** regular troops, who were more likely to be in the area only occasionally and based in a hidden camp while a particular operation was being implemented.

The Australian aim was not to defeat the enemy in major battle, but to gain control of their area (or Tactical Area of Responsibility — TAOR). This could be achieved by cutting off the guerrilla forces from their sources of food, money and recruits in the villages. If the VC were denied food and supplies, they either had to focus on getting new supplies rather than fighting, or they had to withdraw to other, safer areas.

The Australians had three main ways of achieving this: by **cordon and search of villages**; by **search and destroy operations against enemy camps**; and by **patrolling and ambushing the enemy** as they moved through the area. It was rare to have a large-scale battle.

Most operations were at a company level (about 120 men), or a platoon level (about 30 men). Most required stealth, patience, discipline and training. For most of the time on patrol the Australians were not in contact with the enemy — though there was always the possibility that such contact might happen at any time. Most patrols did not even see the enemy. Men might stay out on patrol for up to six weeks, carrying 5–7 days' food that could be re-supplied as needed by helicopter.

Patrols were not pleasant. The conditions were generally hot, often in pouring rain and mud, with snakes, leeches, little food and barely enough water. Food often had to be eaten cold. Men could not smoke (and many were addicted to nicotine). They had to know how to move safely through thick jungle, mined roads and tracks and open paddy fields, all while carrying heavy loads. They had to know how to treat innocent locals, as well as how

Australian Tactics in Vietnam (1ATF)

1966-1971

1

Highlight Nui Dat on the map
Identify the water area

Background

Phuoc Tuy was completely controlled by the VC and was used as a major store area for its operations

1st Australian Task Force (1ATF) began operations in Phuoc Tuy Province in 1966

Two infantry battalions, one SAS squadron, armoured personnel carriers, artillery, engineers, other support troops

1968: Increased to three battalions and a squadron of Centurion tanks

Often criticised by US forces for not using US methods of large-scale search and destroy missions



2

Why did Australia and the US use different tactics?

Tactics (background)

- 1ATF was specially trained counter-revolutionary force
- Australia understood 'low intensity' tactics of the Vietcong and had ideas how to counter them
  - Based on tactics used by Commonwealth forces in Malaya (1948-60) and Indonesia (1963-66)
- However, the US determined the policy for most of Vietnam
- US focussed on bombing and 'search and destroy' tactics. These were appropriate for them because enemy targets were large, and could be struck with heavy firepower.
- Nature of the Australian province was different and 1ATF focussed more on counter-insurgency tactics

3

Why was it so important to spot the enemy first?

Why would the Communists have retreated rather than staying to fight?

Main objectives

- See the enemy first and open fire first
  - Best chance of inflicting most of the casualties in a contact
  - After about 3 seconds, all enemy in a contact had taken cover in the jungle
  - Enemy would then break contact and withdraw, taking casualties with them
- Difficult to estimate exact number of casualties
  - A dead enemy could not be claimed unless the 1ATF unit had a body
  - A wounded enemy could only be claimed if there was a distinct blood trail or body part
- This often meant an underestimation of enemy casualties
  - Particularly as the enemy sought to carry away their dead to conceal losses

4

What is "insurgency"?

Why would the communists be using "small-scale insurgency"?

Australian tactics

- 1st ATF recognised value of US tactics but prepared for the North Vietnamese to revert to small-scale insurgency
  - Hard to identify and then target by US 'search and destroy' tactics
- Enemy in Phuoc Tuy resorted to small-scale insurgency following Long Tan (August 1966)
- Australians broke tactics down into FOUR main activities
  - Patrolling & Ambushing
  - Security contacts (Night ambushes)
  - Cordon & Search
  - Bunker contacts

5

Why are small, quiet patrols so essential?

Patrolling

- Done in half-platoons and platoons (12 – 24 men)
- Aimed to find out as much as possible about the enemy
- Moved silently through jungle, leaving as little trace as possible
- Tried not to attract attention (US patrols were often too large and noisy)
- Men were normally 3 – 10m apart with weapons ready and completely silent
- Patrols could last up to 6 weeks and were stressful for soldiers – constantly on alert for communist ambushes, booby traps. limited food etc





6

How does the terrain you can see in the photos make patrolling difficult?

Approx % of the time the Australians fired first?

How does the Communists' casualty rate compare that of the enemy?

Are the rates sigificantly affected by who fires first? Why do you think that was?

1ATF Patrol Contacts with the Enemy

- 1ATF units had about 1,500 patrol contacts with the enemy (across entire period)
- When 1st ATF patrols were first to fire, they suffered one casualty for every ten they inflicted.
- However, most patrols did not encounter the enemy most days so it was inefficient as a tactic
- Patrolling footage: https://dl.nfsa.gov.au/module/301/

Table 1: Casualties: Patrol Contacts when 1ATF Patrols Fired First

	Total Contacts	Killed in Action	Wounded in Action	Total Casualties
1ATF	1,083	9	97	106
Enemy	1,083	687	401	1,088

Table 2. Casualties: Patrol Contacts when the Enemy Fired First

	Total Contacts	Killed in Action	Wounded in Action	Total Casualties
1ATF	302	47	181	228
Enemy	302	82	70	152

Source: Analysis of the 1ATF Contact Database 1966–1971. For details of this database, see notes to Table 1.

7

Why do you think there were so few contacts?

Do the figures suggest that enemy ambushes were effective? Why/not?

Ambushes

If patrols identified where enemy moved, ambushes could be set up

They were most effective if patrols were silent and left no evidence of their presence

1ATF infantry launched about 1,000 ambushes in which there was contact with the enemy

1ATF infantry suffered a loss ratio of 1 casualty for every 9 enemy casualties

1ATF patrols frequently operated in enemy base areas
- Disrupted operations; located and destroyed camps and caches
- Degraded communications by contacting and killing couriers
- Chipped away at VC/PAVN strength by inflicting casualties

The enemy succeeded in ambushing 1ATF units on at least 103 occasions



8

Why would it have been difficult for the Australians to ambush the enemy?

What was the impact of the ambushes?

Causing high VC casualties does not necessarily mean ambushes effective. Why?

What was the main purpose of the security contacts?

Security contacts (Night ambushes)

- Australians also became expert at night ambushes
- After patrolling all day, an all-round defensive zone (or 'harbour') was set up for the night
  - Australians hid their bases and kept extremely quiet
  - If enemy had any idea where a 1ATF patrol harbour might be, they had to penetrate a hidden defence that was alert and ready to fire
  - If enemy blundered into it, Australians were well placed to deal with them

9

Cordon & Search

- Primarily used to isolate VC and destroy their supplies
- Surrounded a village and look for night movements.
- The following morning the village for VC and supplies. This involved systematically searching the village or hamlet for weapons or excess supplies, interrogating villagers etc
- VC moved most supplies to bunkers to avoid capture during cordon and search operations
- Footage of a cordon and search operation - https://s3-ap-southeast-2.amazonaws.com/awm-media/collection/F03956/video/4251220.MP4 or https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=DjlhJx0ThoA&t=355 (graphic)

10

What would be some of the issues for Australians using cordon and search tactics?

Why were the bunkers / tunnels so hard to find?

Why were they even harder to destroy?

Communist Bunkers

The communists had bunkers throughout Phuoc Tuy

Simple constructions of layers of logs, stones and earth over small or large excavations in the ground

- There were sometimes five to ten bunkers in one location but could be several hundred

Bunkers provided effective protection against airstrikes and artillery

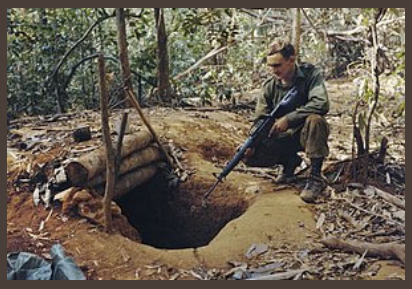
- Used to locate enemy's military and administrative headquarters

- Also to hide supply and weapons caches

One of the main objectives of patrols was to locate these systems without being detected

- Then bring up heavy firepower support to overwhelm the formidable defences

- These attacks involved complex coordination of assets such as artillery, air strikes, helicopter gunships and tanks





11

Why was is so dangerous to infiltrate a tunnel?

How do these casualty rates compare to ambushing?

Bunker contacts

Most dangerous military operation conducted by 1ATF

Of all contacts, only 238 were bunker system contacts. But 1ATF units suffered 549 casualties and inflicted 633 on the enemy.

Therefore, 44% of 1ATF casualties for all contacts were suffered in bunker system contacts

However, seizure of bunker systems was lynchpin of Australian counterinsurgency strategy









12

Why would destroying the tunnels have been the "lynchpin"?

Why was destroying the food supplies effective?

Bunker contacts - Impact

- 1ATF captured over 1800 enemy bunkers systems and base camps – approx. 300 per year
- The average amount of food captured per bunker in 1966 was 1250kg
- The collapse of the food supply had a huge effect on their ability to fight the war. The loss of their supplies forced the VC to enter villages to gain supplies. These missions became predictable which the 1ATF were able to exploit
- Food shortages were significant by 1969 and acute by 1970
- The number of VC in the region collapsed and they sustained only a token presence

13

What evidence is there that destroying the tunnels worked?

Where would the communists have gone?

Conclusions

- 1ATF fought 16 major engagements in the area against VC/PAVN forces sometimes as large as a regiment (three battalions). Most of their engagement with the enemy was through counter-insurgency tactics.
- Australia gained tactical dominance through patrol contacts, ambushes and security contacts. The communists could not stop movement of 1ATF combat units throughout Phuoc Tuy province and often avoided the province
- However, Australians could not influence events significantly beyond Phuoc Tuy.
- Australians did not stay in South Vietnam when US forces started to withdraw
- Within weeks of Australia leaving, the province was controlled by the NLF

14

Based on the conclusion above, what are the issues with judging the effectiveness of Australia's strategies and tactics in Vietnam?

The Battle of Long Tan

18 August 1966

1

Battle of Long Tan

- Happens in an abandoned rubber plantation in Phuoc Tuy, between 108 Australian troops and 1,500-2,500 Viet Cong and NVA soldiers
- Australian signals intelligence had spent several weeks tracking the headquarters of a VC battalion but extensive patrolling failed to make contact
- On 16 August, the battalion set up just outside range of artillery at Nui Dat and shelled the base with mortars, wounding 24 men
- This was responded to with counter-battery fire, and the mortaring ceased
- The following morning B Company of the 6th Batallion of 6RAR went to locate the firing points and direction of withdrawal

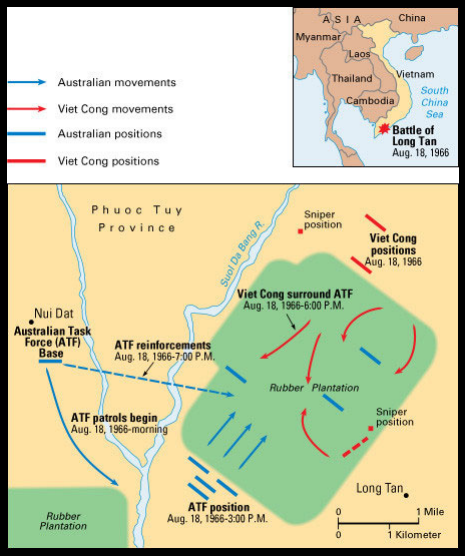
2

What were the two things that happened prior to the Battle of Long Tan?

In either case, did they find the communists?

Battle of Long Tan (contd.)

- D Company relieved B Company around midday on August 18 and engaged a small VC squad sometime in the afternoon
- After forcing them to withdraw, they were faced with small-arms and RPG fire from a much larger force
- They called for artillery support at the same time as a monsoon started, severely reducing visibility and mobility as the VC battalion attempted to encircle and destroy D Company



3 Why would the artillery have been reluctant to provide support?

Battle of Long Tan (contd.)

- The Australians held out throughout the day despite being pinned down and heavily outnumbered, and almost ran out of ammunition before being resupplied by helicopter
- At one point the desperate Australians called down artillery on their own position before withdrawing in order to try to keep the much larger Communist force at bay
- Eventually, a large force of infantry and APCs fought their way to the beleaguered D Company, forcing the VC to withdraw
- After initially believing the battle had been a defeat, it was only the following days when searches of the area revealed the number of VC casualties that the Australians realised they had won a significant victory: 18 Australians were killed and 24 wounded, compared with at least 245 VC dead
- Long Tan was not a normal experience for Australians in Vietnam

4 Why would Australia have originally have considered it a defeat?

How was this battle different to other engagements with the communists?

The Australian Homefront in the Vietnam War

1

Government Policy

- Australian involvement in Vietnam was heavily backed by a series of Liberal Governments, headed by Robert Menzies until 1966 and then by Harold Holt, John Gorton and William McMahon
  - July 1966: "All the war with LBJ"
  - May 1969: "We will go Waltzing Matilda with you"
- This rhetoric was not necessarily matched by actual commitment of troops – Australian participation maxes out at around 8,000 soldiers
  - Goal was to pay an 'insurance policy' rather than make a big war contribution
- The whole exercise was rendered futile in July 1969 when President Richard Nixon announced the Guam Doctrine, which said that America would only assist allies in conflicts involving another superpower from that point on
  - This meant that America would be withdrawing from Vietnam, leaving Australia little choice but to also withdraw
  - Note the timing of this – it will be important later

2

Which aim of Australian foreign policy does "insurance policy" reflect?

Why does US withdrawal lead to Australia withdrawing?

Public Opinion on the Conflict





- Australians generally supported the war at first:
  - When troops were committed in 1965, roughly 2/3 of people supported the war and a similar number were in favour of conscription
  - Can also be seen in the parade for the first group of returned soldiers in 1966 and the rapturous reception received by LBJ on a visit in June of the same year
- This came, largely from an acceptance that the war was necessary to stop Communist expansion

3

Why was communist expansion have been so concerning at this time?

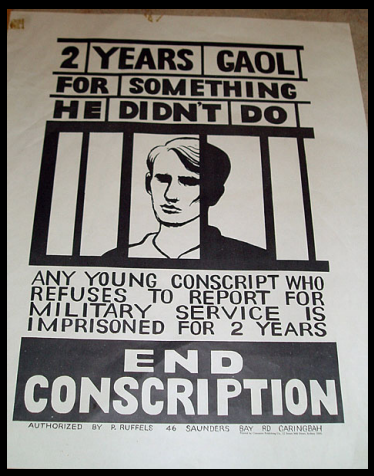
Public Support for the War

Poll Date	Continue to Fight	Bring Back the Troops	Undecided
September 1965	56	28	16
September 1966	61	27	12
May 1967	62	24	14
October 1968	54	38	8
December 1968	49	37	14
April 1969	48	40	12
August 1969	40	55	5
October 1969	39	51	10
October 1970	42	50	8

4

When would you say public sentiment had shifted from pro-war to anti-war?

Australian Opposition to the Vietnam War



- Initially, opposition was fairly limited to small groups:
  - Peace movements on the far left of the Labour Party
  - Some religious objectors
  - Left-Wing University students
  - The Save our Sons movement, a mothers' protest group founded in 1965 to oppose conscription specifically
- NOTE: Opposition to Vietnam War DOES NOT NECESSARILY MEAN a change in opinion on Communism

5 Why does opposition to the war not necessarily mean that people are supportive of communism? How are the different?

Who Opposed the War?





- Opposition to both the war and conscription grew throughout the conflict, for a number of reasons:
  - Unprecedented levels of TV coverage brought the nature of the conflict home to Australians, particularly when it came to atrocities like the My Lai Massacre in 1968
  - Conscription affected more and more families directly
  - Protestors in Australia and America also had an impact on the growth of anti-war sentiment, although the extent of this is debatable
- By 1970, protestors included "bishops, middle-aged public servants and suburban housewives" (Bridge)
- Public support for the war in Australia dipped below 50% for the first time at the end of 1969

6 What are the two main reasons for the drop in support?

The Australian Anti-War Movement

- Inspired by similar American Protests
- The most significant of these was the Moratorium Protest on May 8, 1970, which saw 100,000 people protest in Melbourne, around 200,000 across Australia
- More moratoriums were held on 18 September 1970 and 30 June 1971, although neither were as large
- Largely peaceful protests, as radical groups wanted to retain public support
- Reasons given were varied:
  - War was immoral and inhumane
  - Civil war in Vietnam and Australia should never have intervened in the first place
  - Intervention is no longer worthwhile
  - Not worth the expense
  - Supporting the wrong side





7 Why do anti-war protests not reflect the full extent of the opposition to the war?

The Impact of the Australian anti-war Movement

- Bulk of protesting in Australia comes in 1970, which is AFTER the USA have started de-escalating their commitment
  - What does this suggest about the significance of the protests to Australians in Vietnam?
- Changed how Australians saw the returning soldiers
  - 'heroic' protestors versus 'baby-killer' soldiers (many of whom were conscripts)
- Probably did have some impact on Australian society after the war, but this is outside the scope of our current course

8 Why is it difficult to say the moratorium marches played a role in the decision to withdraw troops from Vietnam?